

Apodemus flavicollis

Field mouse



Length 3¼–5 in
(8.5–13 cm)

Tail 3½–5¼ in
(9–13.5 cm)

Weight ½–1¼ oz
(18–50 g)

Location W. Europe to
W. and C. Asia

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



The yellow throat of this large, long-tailed mouse contrasts with the brown back and yellowish white underparts. The large, prominent eyes and big ears indicate twilight and nocturnal habits, and the long rear feet allow prodigious jumps. The field mouse climbs trees to 66 ft (20 m), searching for seeds, berries, and small creatures such as caterpillars, spiders, and millipedes. It nests in any suitable hole, among roots, or high in a tree trunk, and aggressively chases away other mice, including similar long-tailed field mice (see right).

Apodemus sylvaticus

Long-tailed field mouse



Length 3–4¼ in
(8–11 cm)

Tail 2¾–4¼ in
(7–11 cm)

Weight ⅞–1½ oz
(15–30 g)

Location Europe, N. Africa

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



Sometimes mistaken for a small field mouse (see left), the long-tailed field mouse may have not only a yellow throat but also an orange-brown chest patch. Its upperparts are gray-brown; the underparts, gray-white. Fast and agile, the long-tailed field mouse consumes many foods, including mushrooms, berries, fruit, worms, and insects. It nests in a burrow or tree-hole, marks its territory with urine, and fights intruders violently.

*Micromys minutus*

Harvest mouse



Length 2–3 in
(5–8 cm)

Tail 1¼–3 in
(4.5–7.5 cm)

Weight ⅜–¼ oz
(5–7 g)

Location W. Europe to
E. Asia

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



This tiny mouse is the only Old World rodent with a prehensile tail. It feeds on seeds, including the heads of wheat and other farmed cereals, berries, and small animals such as insects and spiders. In the breeding season, the female gives birth to about 1–8 young, occasionally 12 or more, after a pregnancy lasting 21 days. However, if food becomes scarce, she may eat them—a self-survival strategy that occurs in various rodents.

COLORATION

The harvest mouse has yellowish or reddish brown upperparts and a mainly white underside. The face is rounded but the snout is pointed.



BALL-LIKE NEST

The harvest mouse constructs a spherical nest of finely shredded grass blades and stems, perhaps using an old bird's nest as a base, in a thicket or grassy clump. It is about 3–4¼ in (8–12 cm) across, and is located some 20–51 in (50–130 cm) above ground level. The female's breeding nest is more substantial than the regular nest.

*Lemniscomys striatus*

Striped grass mouse



Length 4–5½ in
(10–14 cm)

Tail 4–6 in
(10–15.5 cm)

Weight 1½–2½ oz
(20–70 g)

Location W. and E. Africa

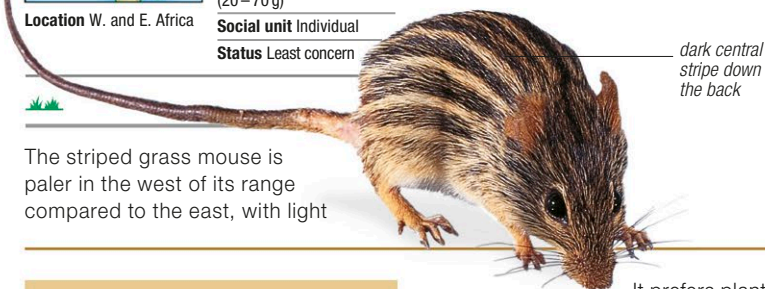
Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



The striped grass mouse is paler in the west of its range compared to the east, with light

stripes along the buff or reddish orange back; underparts are brown-tinged white. It lives mainly on the ground with runways leading to feeding areas of grass stems, leaves, farm crops, and the occasional insect. This nervous, jumpy mouse lives alone and may feign death—"play dead"—or shed the skin from its tail when caught by a predator.



dark central
stripe down
the back

Mallomys rothschildi

Smooth-tailed giant rat



Length 13½–15 in
(34–38 cm)

Tail 14–16½ in
(36–42 cm)

Weight 2–3¼ lb
(0.95–1.5 kg)

Location New Guinea

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



This rat, also known as Rothschild's woolly rat because of its long, thick fur, has an almost black back, reddish brown upper parts, and pale underside, perhaps with a white band running from the belly up each side. Its scaly tail is brown at the base but turns white about halfway along its length. The smooth-tailed giant rat scampers through the trees in search of shoots, leaves, and other plants, gripping with its sharp-clawed feet. It usually lives in a hollow tree but sometimes inhabits holes in the ground. Females are thought to produce only one offspring per litter.

Rattus rattus

Roof rat



Length 6½–9½ in
(16–24 cm)

Tail 7–10 in
(18–26 cm)

Weight 5–9 oz
(150–250 g)

Location Worldwide
(except polar regions)

Social unit Variable

Status Least concern



Also called the ship rat, black rat, or house rat, in early Roman times the roof rat spread around the world from Asia in ships or crates of cargo.

It prefers plant matter, such as seeds and fruit, but it can survive on insects, dead animals, feces, and refuse. Roof rats gather in "packs" of 20–60 and may intimidate larger animals such as dogs. The basic coloration is black, but shades of

brown also occur, with gray to white on the belly, and whitish or pink feet. The female produces 4–10 young after a gestation period of 20–24 days. This rat can run, climb, and swim very well, and makes a nest of twigs and grass, but often nests in a roof cavity and uses almost

any material. The fleas carried by roof rats spread diseases among humans, including bubonic plague, which has killed hundreds of millions of people through the centuries.



long, hairless tail
for balance